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Abstract

Sweden, with a high level of political participation and an avant-garde position regarding internet access, broadband and social media penetration in the population, is a critical case for studying social media in relation to political participation. Three types of users – members of political parties, members of interest organizations, and non-members – are interviewed in focus groups about their attitudes to political content in the social network site Facebook. The discussions show that although practices and attitudes vary, using social network sites alone does not drive previously inactive respondents to political participation. Respondents who are members of interest organizations view social network sites as valuable tools for participation, whereas respondents who are not refrain from sharing political views with their friends. They are exposed to political content and requests for participation, but prefer generally to remain passive.

Keywords

political mobilization, political participation, social media, social network sites, Web 2.0

Introduction

Beyond the counterproductive debate about whether social network sites are good or bad for democracy, empirical studies in the social sciences are starting to form a picture of how this form of communication might affect political participation (among others, Baumgartner and Morris, 2010; Davis, 2010; Gil de Zuniga et al., 2009; Hindman, 2008;

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Leung, 2009; Nielsen, 2011; Norris, 2002; Park et al., 2009; Schlozman et al., 2010; Woodly, 2008; Zhang et al., 2010).

It is important not to fall for the temptation to think that everything about political behaviour online is inherently new and cannot be aided by established theories. At the same time, believing that there is nothing new at all with participation through social network sites does not help research. Existing concepts must be continuously challenged.

Whereas a number of studies have been made in a US context, empirical work in European countries is still scarce. By integrating empirical work made in different national, cultural and demographic contexts into the existing literature, comparative research will be made easier.

Sweden is a country with a high internet and social media penetration rate. Eighty-four per cent of the population have access to a broadband connection. Eighty-four per cent of Swedes born in 1977–1994 are weekly social network site users, Facebook being the most popular service with about 4 million users (Facebook.com, 2011; Findahl, 2010; Gustafsson and Höglund, 2011).¹ Sweden ranks as the number one nation according to the ICT Development Index calculated by the International Telecommunication Union (Leckner and Facht, 2010). Finally, Sweden is also a country with a comparatively high level of political activity (Teorell et al., 2007), of voluntary work (Svedberg et al., 2010; Verba et al., 1995: 80), and of social trust (Zmerli et al., 2007). Sweden is therefore a useful case for finding evidence of people previously not active in politics being recruited into politics through social network sites.

The aim of this article is to explore attitudes, motives and alleged behaviour of social network site users in relation to political participation. Very few empirical studies on political participation and social media in Sweden have been done so far (e.g. Gustafsson and Höglund, 2011). This article is based on focus group interviews with members of political parties, members of interest organizations and people who are not active in politics. The study is guided by the hypothesis that using social network sites lowers thresholds for participation by offering flexible forms of participation and more effective means of spreading information (cf. Joyce, 2010). The specific contribution of this article is exploring possible causal mechanisms related to this hypothesis, as well as presenting empirical research in a new field.

Following this introduction, a brief overview of the theoretical field of political participation and social network sites is provided, and existing research is presented ('What hopes for democracy?'). The guiding hypothesis is introduced ('The Civic Voluntarism Model and social network sites'). After a note on methods, the results from the interviews are presented. The article concludes with a discussion on implications for further research.

What hopes for democracy?

Political participation is defined by Henry Brady (1999: 737) as 'action by ordinary citizens directed toward influencing some political outcomes'. The concept is further specified by ruling out political attitudes, learning and knowledge, instead restricting the term for active participation to situations where the goal is to influence decisions made by government bodies and/or the selection of government officials (see also Verba et al., 1995: 38).

The strict definition of politics as limited to government decisions and actions has been questioned in favour of a more open definition. Actions directed towards private bodies or public opinion might also be seen as political participation (Conge, 1988: 344f). Given that a significant number of political issues are not unambiguously under state control, it is logical that the targets of political action are diversifying. Actions are directed not only towards the formal political institutions, but also towards – *inter alia* – international institutions and private businesses (Micheletti, 2003; Norris, 2002).

Another problem concerning the conceptual limits of political participation concerns the nature of action itself. This is a subject that has been discussed concerning allegedly ‘new’ forms of participation emerging from activities made possible by the internet. There is no academic consensus on what constitutes an act of political participation (cf. Anduiza et al., 2007: 3). In this study, no finite definition of political participation is used in order to gauge potential changes in attitudes to what constitutes a political action.

There are few studies devoted to the effects of social network site use on political participation, and those published have come to varying conclusions. Schlozman et al. (2010), using data obtained through the Pew Internet and American Life Project in 2008, find that ‘political engagement on blogs and social networking sites clearly overcomes the historical underrepresentation of younger citizens with respect to political activity’ (p. 501), and also find that the relationship between socioeconomic status and participation is weaker for those using social networking sites, but also find it ‘premature to conclude [...] that interactive forms of online political participation hold the key to unlocking the association between political participation and socio-economic status’ (p. 503). Zhang et al. (2010), relying on a telephone survey in a mid-sized city in southwestern United States, come to the conclusion that using social networking sites has a positive effect on civic participation – ‘activities that address community concerns through non-governmental or non-electoral means’ (p. 76) – but not on political participation. Baumgartner and Morris (2010), surveying US college students, compare people ‘getting news from a social networking web site’ and people getting news from other types of media. Their conclusion is that using social networking sites for news consumption does not lead to increased political participation compared to relying on for instance online news sites. Park et al. (2009), studying Texan students, find that using Facebook for political and civic purposes is positively correlated with political and civic participation offline.

Existing research does not give clear guidance on whether the specific use of social network sites does indeed have any effects on political behaviour. The studies differ in methodology, measurements and sampled populations. Using survey questions based on existing conceptualizations of political behaviour might obscure changes in attitudes. In order to aid a more systematic analysis of the field, this study aims to widen the diversity and explore the motives of the researched population.

The Civic Voluntarism Model and social network sites

One way of conceptualizing explanatory factors of participation includes focusing on incitements for participation. Bäck et al. (2006) focus on collective versus selective incitements. Collective incitements are related to the probability of actually influencing a

political outcome and selective incitements include sense of duty, the desire to express oneself, the desire to be entertained, and so on. A list of resource factors (skills, income, knowledge, access to social networks, etc.) is added in order to give a complex explanation. Another way of conceptualizing this is to make a distinction between motivational factors (such as life satisfaction, political interest, etc.) and capacitating factors (income, civic skills, organization membership, etc.) (Teorell et al., 2007).

In the Civic Voluntarism Model (Verba et al., 1995), explanatory factors include resources (time, money, skills), engagement (interest, knowledge, efficacy), and recruitment (p. 269). Using social network sites might hypothetically influence all three categories.

Whereas resources in themselves would not be affected by using social network sites, a wider repertoire of political activities (such as various forms of online participation) is available compared to, for instance, attending meetings in formal organizations (Joyce, 2010). Lowering the cost of participation by making it more flexible might make participating more attractive.

Considering engagement, some researchers have found causal effects of social media on political knowledge, explaining this with the 'surprise effect' of unexpected political content, offsetting the effect of politically interested people actively searching for political information on the internet contrasted with people not interested in politics actively screening out political information, contributing to a widened knowledge gap (Cantijoch et al., 2008: 6; cf. Prior, 2007; Sweetser and Kaid, 2008).

Previous research has also established a strong connection between social capital and political participation; in particular the link between weak ties and participation. According to Mark S. Granovetter (1973: 1374), 'people rarely act on mass-media information unless it is also transmitted through personal ties; otherwise one has no particular reason to think that an advertised product or an organization should be taken seriously'. This relationship has been found in the political field in several studies. If a person's social network is larger, the chance that he or she will be asked to participate is higher (Teorell, 2003). Organizing weak ties in social network sites allows for an individual to stay connected to brief acquaintances when moving to another geographical area, thereby expanding the network and increasing the possibility of recruitment. Steinfeld et al. (2008) found, using panel data, that Facebook use was strongly associated with higher outcomes of bridging social capital.

The effect of weak ties on political action is not undisputed. It has been claimed that conversations made possible by social network sites are not enough for creating successful mobilization. Strong ties would be necessary in order for people to build up the stamina needed to face imminent danger, or at least arduous work (Gladwell, 2010; Morozov, 2011). This argument, however, is concentrated around 'high-risk activism'. At least in democratic states, political participation is not always of a high-risk nature and the state is not necessarily a dangerous enemy. The argument is also directed towards an unfairly constructed counter-argument maintaining that social media renders hierarchical organizations obsolete and envisions a political future largely disconnected from old inequalities and the formal political system (cf. Shirky, 2008). Empirical research on the effects of social network sites should not fall into the trap of fighting straw men.

It is not a given fact that individuals not already active in politics will take advantage of participating just because it is made easier by technology. It might also be the case that

people active in politics take greater advantage of the possibilities of social media, organizing more effectively and enhancing their influence on the political system (Breindl and Gustafsson, 2011).

Despite claims that new forms of media might be connected to political cynicism and apathy, empirical research has shown that informational use of media might make people more inclined to discuss political matters, and in the long run increase engagement and participation levels (Gil de Zúñiga et al., 2009: 557f.). This also seems to be true for social network sites (Ellison et al., 2011). The fact that digital media such as social network sites are interconnected with other types of media and communication presents yet another challenge to the isolation of the individual effects of social network site use. The relation between old theories of the interplay of media and the political on the one hand, and the perceived need for developing new theories for explaining how digital media function on the other, make it difficult to anchor empirical research on the political use of social network sites in solid media theory (Harrison and Barthel, 2009; cf. Scolari, 2009: 959f.).

Taking this into account, the Civic Voluntarism Model is expected to be valid also for social network site users, with the potential effects of social network sites mentioned above. If the hypothesis has any value, we would observe people already active in politics benefiting from the effective ways of disseminating information and recruiting contacts. People not active in politics would be more inclined to participate when exposed to political content by contacts because of the increased flexibility, *ceteris paribus*.

Method

For this study, 50 respondents were interviewed in six focus group interviews. Three of these interviews were conducted online and three were conducted offline. Focus groups are useful when the purpose is not to generalize, but to study such motives, experiences and thought processes of individuals as are not obtainable through extensive methods like surveys; to explore a new field; to generate hypotheses; and to develop interview guides (Rezabek, 2000; Stewart and Williams, 2005: 398). As the aim of this study was to explore the reasoning of social network site users in relation to political content and discussion, using the Civic Voluntarism Model as a guiding framework, this was deemed an appropriate method. A further reason for using focus group interviews rather than individual interviews is that since political participation and political discussions in social network sites is a new experience to many people, the group setting would allow for respondents to react to each other's stories and compare their own experiences (Hundley and Shyles, 2010: 419).

An additional aim of the study was to discover differences in the reasoning of people who are active in political or interest organizations as opposed to people not active in organized politics. The theoretical motive for interviewing both members of political parties and members of interest organizations was that people who are active in politics in a 'traditional way' in a political party might differ in their attitudes from people active in interest organizations, considered to be connected to newer forms of social engagement. For this reason, the groups were homogeneously composed, i.e. two groups were comprised of members of political parties; two groups by members of interest groups; and two groups by people neither active in politics nor members of interest groups, one in each category being conducted online and the other offline.

The respondents of the online groups were recruited using snowball sampling. These interviews were conducted from 18 November to 8 December 2009, using an online discussion tool. Each online focus group interview lasted for about two weeks, with an additional week for allowing respondents to amend their answers.

The respondents of the traditional focus groups were recruited by contacting local political party branches and interest organizations (environmental, human rights, and sexual information), as well as university students. These interviews were conducted in December 2009–July 2010, each interview lasting about one hour. The interviews were audiotaped and transcribed.

The final sample contained 50 individuals with a majority being 19–34-year-olds, mostly highly educated people or university students. The online and offline groups did not differ from each other regarding the content of the discussions. However, responses from respondents in the online groups were generally longer and more eloquent, whereas dynamic interaction between respondents was more intense in the offline groups.

All quotes from the interviews in this article are translated from Swedish by the author. In the quotes, information is given about what group the quoted participant was in. This information is annotated in the following way: traditional/non-organized (TN); online/non-organized (ON); traditional/political party members (TP); online/political party members (OP); traditional/interest organization members (TI); and online/interest organization members (OI).

Reacting to political content on social network sites

Social network sites as a resource for participation

Hypotheses connecting changed forms or levels of political participation caused by the use of social network sites mention lowered thresholds for participation as a result of faster, more effective spread of information and more flexible forms for participation (Joyce, 2010). How do users themselves perceive these allegedly lowered thresholds?

Political party members explicitly stated that they had gotten a Facebook account for obtaining information from their party and discussing politics with other party members. They were encouraged to do so by leadership and peers. Both party members and interest organization members viewed Facebook and other social network sites and other social media services as valuable tools for their engagement, especially for intra-organizational communication and for information. Non-organized respondents, for obvious reasons, did not report any changes to the way they engaged in politics.

Using social network sites for intra-organizational communication had also changed the way the organizations functioned. Political party members claimed that the increased speed of politics was tangible. It was perceived as a sense of urgency and a need for getting the message out as quickly as possible. This is a development that has been studied in prior research in political communication (Blumler and Kavanagh, 1999), but social network sites might have made it a personally felt feature of political life, also for local part-time politicians. Interest organization members did not mention this. This could be due to the fact that traditional media has always watched politicians more closely. Non-organized respondents did not report any changes to intra-organizational communication.

Party members mentioned that social network sites had eroded internal hierarchies, as collaboration across local party branches had been made easier. As information no longer had to go through central boards, informal networks were perceived as easier to form and maintain. Interest organization members did not mention this, which is probably due to the fact that the responsibilities of players within the formal political system are different from those outside it. Political parties rule territories, make laws, and have to strike deals with other parties, and for this reason, they have to maintain discipline in keeping votes along party lines. Therefore, hierarchies are stronger than in issue-based organizations and any loosening up of the hierarchies is felt more deeply. Non-organized respondents did not report any changes to hierarchies.

The special responsibilities of politicians differ from members of interest organizations and from the politically inactive. The growth of communication and the increasing speed is felt by everyone, but in a qualitatively different way by decision makers. And at the same time as social network sites change the way that activists and people with a political interest in general channel their engagement, the effects and experiences are clearly different for those engaged in the formal political system.

Interest organization members also stated that the use of social network sites had made internal communication and collaboration easier. In contrast to political party members, this was not viewed as a loosening up of hierarchies. Instead, the focus was on ease and a wider exchange of information.

The non-organized respondents also mentioned increased speed and a larger inflow of information. Although it was sometimes met with feelings of stress, it was for obvious reasons not perceived as a challenge or development of existing organizations.

The possibility in Facebook of inviting contacts to groups was celebrated in all three categories. For some of the interest organization members, groups were rated as a good way of getting media attention for an event or for a cause: if a particular group attracted a certain number of members, traditional mass media would report on it. This dynamic between Facebook groups and media reports was on the contrary commented on with derision from non-organized respondents. They felt that too much was made of social network site participation, and that 'real' participation was far more effective and worthy of respect. Remembering the point raised by Gladwell (2010) about the risk of participation through social network sites rendering traditional activism obsolete, this was only mentioned as a potential problem by the non-organized respondents. This seems to indicate that actively organizing through groups is more important for those who already have an organizational affiliation.

That organizing through groups can be useful for the non-organized is, however, also true. For respondents in all categories, Facebook groups were seen as a way of building a sense of group identity and self-efficacy in relation to participation, as is seen from this exchange between two respondents in the non-organized category:

TN1: In my previous school, students protested against the food because it was too bad and we had to pay for it and then we protested. No-one had lunch at school one day and we made sandwiches, and it worked. It was organized through Facebook.

TN2: But what Facebook can do, is that, like, if you want to question something, you don't want to be on your own. You want to have people with you. And through Facebook you might find

more people who think like me. And then you might not be so afraid of taking a stand. That you could find people who think alike and then I might dare to do so because others do it. That it becomes like peer pressure but also this peer support.

The significance of the Groups function in Facebook for participation offline has been noted in earlier research (Park et al., 2009). The quoted exchange points to mechanisms of building social capital and self-esteem, and self-efficacy – factors that have great importance for participation (Bäck et al., 2006; Verba et al., 1995). Although formal organizations and strong relational ties are important for raising fighting spirits, the mere knowledge of not being alone can function as a factor making participation desirable.

Several perceived negative aspects countered positive aspects of organizing through Facebook. Non-organized respondents complained that political issues were reduced to a for/against dichotomy. In combination with a perceived tendency to harshness in political discourse in groups, this deterred people from joining groups. The dichotomization of political conversation online and tendencies towards ideological clustering has been thoroughly studied over the last decades, recently also in social network sites (Gaines and Mondak, 2009). However, scholars have come to varying conclusions of whether that is a bad or a good thing for deliberation. Ideologically homogeneous clustering might bring about increased political participation. Non-consensual contestation of political views can function as a counter-hegemonic strategy, especially for marginalized groups (Dahlberg, 2007: 841), but might also encourage extremist views (Wojcieszak, 2010: 651). Social network sites have features that are similar to online discussion forums, long known as sites of harsh conversation, but also a relational aspect that is different from these. The surprise effect of noticing a Friend joining a group might make users inclined to look for more information on a subject, but the bitter and sarcastic tone used by political activists seem to scare people away. The joy of arguing can be differently experienced by someone who is used to political debate and someone who is not.

Views also differed as to whether Facebook was appropriate for serious matters at all. For political party members, this was not a problem. Being a party member and a politician makes you automatically an ideological figure. But for one interest organization member, politics did not belong in the private sphere and was not considered an appropriate subject for casual conversation among friends. The implications of how one views the 'right place' of politics in everyday life are obvious also when discussing whether it is appropriate to express political views at all on Facebook. For non-organized respondents, expressing political views was something that they would never do. One respondent in one of the non-organized focus groups stated that she was afraid that potential employers in the future would disapprove of her views. Another respondent in one of the interest organization member groups said that she had taken down political information from her Facebook page before applying for jobs. Here we face two theoretically interesting problems. On the one hand, party members, interest organization members and non-organized respondents have differing views of how appropriate it is to express political views. For party members it is not a problem: it is already an integrated part of personality. For interest organization members, ideologically salient issues are not to be shared. For non-organized respondents, politics is not to be discussed at all. On the other hand, there are feelings of insecurity as to whether Facebook is to be considered as a legitimate site for

political discussion. This connects to danah boyd's (2008) research on social network sites as semi-public sites with collapsed contexts. Are these norms stable across platforms? Do the same norms apply for people discussing politics in social network sites and offline, are norms evolving as a result of collapsed contexts making it more difficult to separate sites for conversation, or are norms different offline and in social network sites?

Concerning resources, respondents in all three categories report improvements in speed and efficiency in recruiting contacts. Party members and interest organization members report changes in internal communication. Party members report changes in internal hierarchies. Party members feel that social network sites are valid spaces for discussing politics. Interest group members refrain from taking an ideological stand. Non-organized respondents do not discuss politics at all.

Weak ties, 'slacktivism' and social network sites as effective sites for participation

Several respondents, in all groups, expressed concerns with the efficiency of participation through Facebook. One line of reasoning pointed to the fact that just joining a Facebook group does not change anything. There was scepticism towards what some scholars have called 'clicktivism' or 'slacktivism' (Karpf, 2010), participating only to the extent that you express your benevolence towards political and social issues. Utterances of this sort were much more prevalent among non-organized respondents than among political party and interest organization members. People who are used to participating in various activities and also trying to activate others are more used to being engaged across different arenas and participating in varying degrees. Active engagement in an organization often entails going to meetings, discussing with like-minded people, and the occasional street action. This makes you view Facebook as a valuable add-on to your other activities. But if Facebook-based activism is the only part of engagement that you see, you might perceive it in a more negative way. For yet others, joining groups is a way of participating while not being able to do more because of time restraints. As one respondent put it:

OI1: [Joining a Facebook group] demands a MINIMUM level of activity on my side, so as a political act it feels pretty simple, close to uncommitted. It's mostly a fun thing. This is annoying, but at the same time it's my only forum for political engagement now, as family and work take up all my time.

It seems evident that for some people, participating through Facebook was not seen as a 'serious' participatory activity. On the other hand, some respondents seemed to view participatory activities in Facebook as something that should lead to such 'real' activities.

Some respondents were cautious with their political views, and some of them did not express any political views on Facebook. Deciding whether to express views or not was not the only point of consideration. How political views were stated proved to be at least as important. One political party member expressed distress over not being able to separate her different identities as a politician, a co-worker and a friend. Conversely, some political party respondents mentioned that the use of social network sites had changed their relations to fellow party members and others as their Facebook profiles revealed a previously unknown

diversity of character. Especially respondents in the political party groups mentioned that they were careful with what groups they were a member of, what views they expressed, and even which Friends they had. This, again, leads us back to the problems posed above about what kind of space it is that social network sites really constitute.

Concerning attitudes to the effectiveness of participation through social network sites, political party members and interest organization members were positive, whereas non-organized respondents were negative.

Responding to recruitment

All respondents in all groups said that they were approached with recruitment attempts. Many of the mentioned recruitment attempts were in the form of invitations to join a group or a cause with a political purpose. A recurring theme in political participation research is the fact that people who are in social networks with politically active people and who have participated in the past are more likely to be asked (Teorell, 2003; Verba et al., 1995). But social network site users seem to be approached regardless of whether they are known activists or not. The silver bullet of the hypothesis that social network site use would lead to increased participation is based on the possibilities of enlarged networks and more recruitment attempts (Steinfeld et al., 2008: 435).

Here, a difference could be seen between respondents in organizations and respondents who were not members of organizations. Among organization members, reactions were mixed: some respondents said that they sometimes accepted invitations or other types of recruitment attempts, but that this was depending on who sent the invitation and what the cause was. Another factor to take into account was that accepting too many invitations could be seen in a negative way. Cluttering your feed or your profile page with political statements might be considered as undermining your credibility.

Non-organized people were more sceptical. Some respondents felt that recruitment attempts were somewhat of an intrusion and did not want to respond to them at all, though other respondents mentioned that invitations and other recruitment attempts were an excuse for learning more about an issue:

TN1: Like, generally speaking, my friends on Facebook are not that politically active, so it's not often that I get any – well, that there's a status update or someone with political purposes in any way. But on the other hand you get like 'the Sweden Democrats shouldn't be in Parliament' and a lot of that stuff all the time, and in one way I think that it's–

TN2: Like peer pressure.

TN1: Yes, and it feels so forced in a way. In ninety-nine cases out of a hundred I don't join the group almost as a protest, because I think that, well, in that case I'd like to choose for myself what groups I want to be a member of, but then it would be impossible to find them. [...]

TN2: I totally know the feeling. I'm not a member of a lot of groups. But especially before the EU election you got a lot of requests and now I got one from a Green Party guy with the election next year approaching. Now it's a bit early for that. But, like, I think it could be a good way,

because even if you're not that interested you might check it out anyway and that could be an advantage for these parties and people that want you to join the group. So it's a completely new way to reach people. [...] But going further, joining groups – that you mightn't do, but you would still look stuff up.

This exchange illustrates that the reaction to a recruitment attempt might not be as simple as agreement or rejection. The first speaker got annoyed over recruitment attempts in Facebook, in part because he did not feel that it was a *personal* invitation (as he stated shortly afterwards in the discussion), and because he felt that it was something forced upon him. The second speaker agreed with the first in the sense that she, too, did not join groups. She also pointed out that even if one did not actually join a group, the invitation in itself could still be a reason for learning more about the issue.

A major reason for not responding was the sheer mass of invitations. The ease with which invitations can be spread means that an infinite number of calls for action and other recruitment attempts can be sent to contacts. Individual social network site users are, however, not able to respond to an infinite number of requests. Several respondents complained about this. It was difficult to know whether the original senders or creators of the message were honest or not. Whereas it seemed that respondents in the political party and interest organization focus groups in general received more invitations, non-organized respondents complained about the problem of vast amounts of unsolicited invitations with equal fervour.

Several respondents in all focus groups stated that their willingness to accept an invitation depended a great deal on who tried to recruit them and what relation they had. Relationship was not the only factor for credibility. There was general scepticism among many respondents. One non-organized respondent stated that she trusted invitations from close friends more, but also mentioned that she was inclined to listen to authorities that she did not know at all, for instance on Twitter. For her, Twitter was a better way of obtaining valuable information than Facebook.²

When asked whether invitations and other recruitment attempts had 'spilled over' into participatory activities taking place 'outside' of the realm of social media, respondents offered varying answers. Although respondents in scientific studies generally tend to over-report political participation because of social desirability bias (Brady, 1999: 789f.), few respondents could initially think of particular instances. When given time to think, answers were more mixed and also showed the complicated relationship between information and action and between what is considered a direct recruitment attempt and what is mere information.

Concerning recruitment, all respondents encounter recruitment attempts. Political party members and interest organization members sometimes accept these invitations, whereas non-organized respondents generally do not.

Engagement and information

Because recruitment attempts in social network sites can be considered as intrusive and unwanted, perhaps especially by people who are not active in political parties and interest organizations, the less aggressive and overt that recruitment attempts are, the more pervasive they might turn out to be.

While invitations can be annoying, information was generally seen as one of the good things with the political content on Facebook. Several respondents in all focus groups pointed this out. For many people who are not especially interested in politics, social network sites are latent tools for political communication and information sharing.

Sharing information is not an act that is necessarily done without a motive. It can also be a subtle recruitment attempt. Some political party and interest group members reported that they had a clear strategy for what they should post in order to make their friends and contacts interested in important issues. Some respondents claimed that they had acted on information that they got in this way.

ON1: I have never become aware of a new political phenomenon (using a narrow definition) via Facebook. But I have however become MORE aware, and maybe engaged more emotionally in various phenomena, because I have been 'nagged' via Facebook.

OP1: I have reacted to a lot of issues that I have been made aware of through Facebook. Though not through joining groups but rather discussing it at coffee breaks or otherwise or by writing emails or letters to the decision-makers concerned.

These quotes describe two ways of acting on information provided via Facebook. The respondent in the first quote stated that she did not feel that she got any new information from Facebook. On the other hand, she is consistently reminded of political issues that she cares about and encouraged by contacts that share her views. Strengthening pre-existing views is probably an effect of using Facebook as well as of being informed about news and could in the end contribute to participatory activities (cf. Wojcieszak, 2010). The second quote serves as a reminder that although an individual has no recorded political activity within Facebook or any other social network site, this does not mean that Facebook does not prompt participatory activities among users. Only studying the social network site itself is apparently not sufficient for measuring its effects on its users (Wojcieszak, 2010: 650). The subtle nature of Facebook politics means that both manifest and latent participation (Ekman and Amnå, 2009) should be studied to capture the full extent of the effects of social network sites on participation.

Concerning engagement and information, all respondents value the increased possibilities of informing oneself about political issues. Political party members and interest organization members, anticipating the wary attitude of non-organized people towards political content, use subtle forms of influencing contacts.

Revisiting the Civic Voluntarism Model: Directions for further study

This study offers limited possibilities for drawing general conclusions about how individual users of social network sites are affected by political content and recruitment attempts. With that in mind, there are still several interesting aspects to discuss and to bear in mind for further research.

The discussions show that the use of social network sites cannot be reduced to a simple effect causing all users to act in the same way. Whereas respondents active in organizations

tended to view the political side of Facebook as an important new channel for intra-organizational communication, a great source for political news, and a way of influencing contacts, respondents who did not belong to organizations tended to hold more sceptical views of the political content. But even if not many of the non-organized respondents took active part in political discussions or participatory activities – neither in the medium itself, nor by engaging in ‘real life’ activities – these more passive users were also affected by recruitment attempts, by things they saw that their friends did, links their friends posted, and so on. It is time that the distinction between manifest and latent participation is brought into the research field.

Revisiting the civic voluntarism model proposed by Verba et al. (1995), several interesting aspects emerged from the discussions. Social network sites might potentially lower the thresholds for participating by introducing new and more flexible forms in which it can be done, but this is not enough for making non-actives ready for participation. Other factors, such as a reluctance to make political views known to friends and other contacts as well as insecurity concerning the credibility of campaigns, seemed to offset this among several non-organized respondents. A widespread scepticism towards ‘clicktivism’ (Karpf, 2010) also functions as a deterring factor. Returning to the Gladwell debate, the threat does not seem to be that social network site users think too much of social network sites, but rather that non-actives think too little of it and fail to see it as a valuable extension of traditional political participation. Among organized respondents, the enhanced flexibility seemed to be appreciated as a tool for aiding their engagement, especially concerning communication. One of the most interesting future lines of research is the study of the way that social network sites pose a challenge to existing hierarchies in organizations – both within the formal political system and without.³

The possibility to recruit and coordinate people quickly and on a larger scale seemed to be offset by other factors deterring non-actives from engaging. The number of recruitment attempts itself might have a deterrent effect.

Studying the factors in the civic voluntarism model associated with political knowledge and efficacy – ‘engagement’ – might be an especially fruitful way forward. The reluctance among non-organized respondents to engage in participatory activities might make more subtle forms of influencing each other attractive. These influences might translate into subsequent participation, but probably this will very often be an indirect process and difficult to observe.

The ‘discovery’ of a group of people who are social network sites users, interested in politics, but who do not let it show in their digital presence has at least two implications for further research in this field. Quantitative research on social network sites has to a large degree been occupied with content analysis of profile pages. This misses out on uses of the internet that do not show up on profile pages and in blog comments. Qualitative research dealing with the political aspects of social media has to a large degree been occupied with studying activists and not people who have a more passive relationship with politics.

A lot of research in the field of political participation and new media has been done on small, culturally homogeneous samples. This contribution is no exception. Comparative studies are much needed. Another limitation of this study is that the interviews it is based on were made at one particular point in time. The connection between changes in behaviour and perceptions in relation to media use would be easier to find by the use of time-sensitive data.

A productive way of continuing the study of the political content in social network sites should be to employ mixed-method strategies in order to explore the complicated relations between information and action. This would include theoretical development when it comes to definitions of political actions, empirical studies on how social media changes internal hierarchies in political and interest organizations as well as the interplay between organizations and networks in creating political influence, and comparative cross-country and times-series analyses of how political behaviour in social media changes over time.

The relationship between different groups of politically interested people – party members, interest organization members, and the non-organized public – is changing, creating new and potentially far-reaching developments in the way that democracies work. At the same time, further research on the relationship between social network sites and political participation must take into account that the effects vary depending on whether you belong to a political party, another type of organization, or no organization at all.

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Notes

1. The number is based on information given by Facebook's advertisement department (when you create an ad., the estimated reach for a target population of an entire country should equate to the number of users that Facebook claims in that country). However, the numbers are probably inflated since it is possible to register multiple profiles and it is impossible to say by how much. Sweden has a population of circa 9.5 million (2011).
2. Twitter is a micro-blogging service that allows for posts limited to 140 characters. A minority of the respondents were Twitter users – 10 out of 50 – but those who were seemed to have developed different strategies for using Twitter on the one hand and Facebook on the other hand. Whereas relations on Facebook were graded on a scale of closeness, other factors were at play in Twitter.
3. This also came up in in-depth individual interviews made with politicians for comparative reasons but not included in this study.

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